

BIHAR ORIGIN

Aloo Chokha

Mashed Spiced Potatoes
The Simplest Comfort in Bihari Cooking

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Aloo Chokha

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DISCLAIMER

Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Humble Mash That Completes a Meal

Chokha, as a category, refers to Bihar's tradition of mashed, spiced vegetable dishes, typically built around a single roasted or boiled vegetable dressed simply with mustard oil, onion, garlic, and chili. Aloo chokha — mashed spiced potato — is the most approachable and universally loved of the chokha family, a dish nearly every Bihari household makes regularly, requiring little more than boiled potatoes and a handful of pantry staples.

Its simplicity is exactly the point. Where richer curries rely on layers of spice and long cooking, chokha's appeal comes from the clean, direct flavors of raw mustard oil, sharp onion, and fresh chili stirred into warm mashed potato — a dish that tastes distinctly of its ingredients rather than any elaborate technique. It's most commonly served alongside litti, forming one half of Bihar's most famous food pairing, though it stands perfectly well on its own alongside plain rice or roti.

For many Bihari families, particularly those living away from the state, aloo chokha carries significant nostalgic weight — it's often the dish people mention first when asked what home cooking tastes like, precisely because its simplicity makes it so easy to recreate anywhere, keeping a taste of Bihar accessible no matter where life has taken someone.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Humble Mash That Completes a Meal, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

One of the most essential dishes in the Bihari "chokha" family of mashed, spiced vegetable preparations. Almost always paired with litti, forming one half of Bihar's most iconic food combination. Valued for its simplicity, requiring minimal ingredients and technique compared to richer curries. Carries significant nostalgic weight for the Bihari diaspora, often cited as a dish that most immediately evokes home cooking.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

10m	5m	4	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	ASSEMBLY TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Pot, for boiling potatoes
- Mixing bowl
- Potato masher or fork

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Aloo chokha keeps refrigerated for up to 2 days, though it's best enjoyed fresh, as raw onion and mustard oil are at their brightest shortly after mixing. It doesn't freeze well, given its simple, fresh preparation style.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the dish

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Potatoes, boiled and peeled	4 medium	500 g	4 medium
Onion, finely chopped	1 small	80 g	1 small
Garlic, minced	2–3 cloves	8 g	2–3 cloves
Green chili, finely chopped	2	2	2
Fresh coriander, chopped	2 tbsp	8 g	2 tbsp
Mustard oil	3 tbsp	45 ml	3 chammach
Lemon juice	1 tbsp	15 ml	1 chammach
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

This dish uses only widely available pantry staples, making it one of the most globally accessible recipes in this entire collection. Mustard oil contributes significantly to the dish's authentic sharp, pungent character, though a neutral oil with a squeeze of extra lemon can approximate the effect if mustard oil is unavailable or not to your taste.

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STEP BY STEP · STEP-BY-STEP

Making Aloo Chokha

01 BOIL THE POTATOES

Boil the potatoes until a knife slides in easily, about 20 minutes. Drain, peel while still warm, and set aside briefly to cool just enough to handle.

02 MASH ROUGHLY

Mash the potatoes with a fork or masher, leaving some texture rather than making a completely smooth puree — chokha is traditionally a little rustic and chunky.



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Making Aloo Chokha, continued

03 MIX IN THE AROMATICS

While the potato is still warm, mix in the chopped onion, minced garlic, green chili, and coriander — the residual warmth helps release the aromatics' flavor into the mash.

Chef tip. mixing the raw onion and garlic in while the potato is still warm, rather than fully cooled, makes a noticeable difference in how well the flavors meld.

04 FINISH WITH MUSTARD OIL AND LEMON

Drizzle in the mustard oil and lemon juice, and season with salt. Mix thoroughly, tasting and adjusting the balance of tang, heat, and pungency to your preference.

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STEP BY STEP · STEP-BY-STEP

Making Aloo Chokha, continued



COOKING CHECKPOINT

Aloo chokha is ready when it has a rustic, slightly chunky texture with the raw onion, garlic, and chili evenly distributed, and a distinct sharp aroma of mustard oil.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served alongside litti as one half of Bihar's most iconic food pairing.
- Also enjoyed simply with plain rice or roti as a light, quick meal.

Family Style

- A shared bowl at the center of the table, scooped alongside litti or rice for everyone to help themselves.

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How to serve, continued

Modern Pairing

- Works surprisingly well as a rustic side dish alongside grilled or roasted vegetables in a non-traditional meal.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Balance Right

- Mixing the aromatics into warm, not hot or cold, potato is the key technique for the best flavor infusion.
- Don't over-mash — chokha's rustic, slightly chunky texture is part of its charm, distinct from a smooth mashed potato.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- Boil and peel the potatoes ahead of time, then mash and season fresh just before serving for the brightest flavor.
- This dish comes together quickly enough that extensive advance preparation usually isn't necessary.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some cooks lightly char the onion and garlic over an open flame before mixing them in, adding a subtle smoky note that echoes the traditional coal-roasted flavor of litti.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

180 kcal	3 g	28 g	7 g	3 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Mustard. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Baingan Chokha	the roasted eggplant version, another classic member of the chokha family.
Tomato Chokha	a roasted tomato version, often served together with aloo and baingan chokha as a trio.
Aloo Chokha with Radish	some households add grated radish for extra crunch and a peppery note.

Can I make this without mustard oil?

Yes, though mustard oil contributes significantly to the traditional flavor — a neutral oil with extra lemon juice is a reasonable substitute.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Why does my chokha taste bland?

Likely needs more salt, lemon, or raw onion and garlic — chokha relies on these bright, sharp flavors rather than complex spicing, so don't be shy with them.

Is this dish very spicy?

It has sharpness from raw onion, garlic, and green chili rather than significant chili heat — adjust the chili quantity to your preference.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Chokha	Bihar's tradition of mashed, spiced vegetable dishes, typically dressed with raw mustard oil.
Sorson ka Tel	Hindi for mustard oil, essential to authentic chokha flavor.
Litti	Bihar's iconic roasted sattu-stuffed dough balls, the classic pairing for this dish.
Achaar	Hindi for pickle, sometimes served alongside chokha for extra tang.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Aloo Chokha

10m	5m
ACTIVE PREP	ASSEMBLY TIME
4	**Easy**
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

DISH

Potatoes	500 g
Onion	80 g
Garlic	8 g
Green chili	2
Fresh coriander	8 g
Mustard oil	45 ml
Lemon juice	15 ml
Salt	6 g

METHOD

01 **Boil the potatoes.** Boil the potatoes until a knife slides in easily, about 20 minutes.

02 **Mash roughly.** Mash the potatoes with a fork or masher, leaving some texture rather than making a completely smooth puree — chokha is traditionally a little rustic and chunky.

03 **Mix in the aromatics.** While the potato is still warm, mix in the chopped onion, minced garlic, green chili, and coriander — the residual warmth helps release the aromatics' flavor into the mash.

04 **Finish with mustard oil and lemon.** Drizzle in the mustard oil and lemon juice, and season with salt.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Potatoes	500 g	☐ Onion	80 g
☐ Garlic	8 g	☐ Green chili	2
☐ Fresh coriander	8 g	☐ Mustard oil	45 ml
☐ Lemon juice	15 ml	☐ Salt	6 g

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